FAMILY ROAD TRIP

🌿 Cantabria + Basque Coast

Wednesday 17 → Sunday 21 June 2026 · 4 nights

David, Lobke & Noah (5) · fly into Santander, central rural base, one move west

✈️ Flights booked | 🚗 Car booked | 🏡 Areitio — book next | 🛏️ Cantabria night — deciding

OUTBOUND	RETURN	BASE 1 · 3 NTS	BASE 2 · 1 NT
Wed · FR6057	**Sun · FR6058**	**Areitio Etxea ↗**	**Cantabria**
CRL 13:05 → SDR 15:00	SDR 09:20 → CRL 11:10 (early!)	rural house · pool · central hub	near Santander · TBD

DRIVING	EST. BUDGET
~480 km	**~€1,900**
short hops + 1 transfer	excl. food & activities

DAY BY DAY — place names are tappable (open in Maps)

DAY 1 · WED 17 JUN — Land & settle into the hub

🚗 Santander Airport → Areitio · **~145 km (1h30)** on the A-8

AFTERNOON

- **15:00** land Santander, collect the car (~15:45 rolling).
- Drive east on the A-8 through green hills; optional leg-stretch in Bilbao.
- **~16:30** arrive Areitio Etxea (check-in from 15:00) — unpack, let Noah loose in the garden/pool.

EVENING

- Easy first night: BBQ in the gazebo, or dinner in nearby Durango / Elorrio.

👦 **Noah:** flight + drive is a big day — keep it gentle. Grab groceries (Eroski, Durango) for relaxed pool breakfasts.

DAY 2 · THU 18 JUN San Sebastián + the flysch coast

🚗 Areitio → San Sebastián **~40 min**, short hops after

MORNING

- Slow start by the pool, then drive to San Sebastián.
- Walk La Concha; ride the Monte Igueldo funicular to the cliff-top vintage fairground — gentle rides for Noah, knockout bay views.

AFTERNOON

- Aquarium of San Sebastián (shark tunnel, touch pools) — also the rainy-day backup.
- ~30 min west to Zumaia: the flysch cliffs & San Telmo hermitage (GoT *Dragonstone*) at Itzurun beach.

EVENING

- **Pintxos crawl** in the Parte Vieja ~19:30 (early = kid-friendly): Gandarías, La Cuchara de San Telmo, Borda Berri.

🍷 ~40-min drive home → **one of you stays off the txakoli**, or make it an early dinner and head back.

DAY 3 · FRI 19 JUN Gaztelugatxe + Urdaibai biosphere

🚗 Areitio → Gaztelugatxe **~50 min**, loop back

MORNING

- Pool, then drive NW to San Juan de Gaztelugatxe — the 241-step causeway to the island chapel. Go early. (book free tickets ↗)

AFTERNOON

- 10 min to Mundaka — famous left-hand surf wave + estuary lunch.
- Then Laida/Laga beaches (wide Urdaibai sands) *or* Gernika (Tree of Gernika, Peace Museum).

EVENING

- Back to Areitio for a **pool evening** + BBQ.

🎟️ Gaztelugatxe needs a **free timed ticket booked in advance** at tickets.bizkaia.eus. No tickets? The car-park-side viewpoint is stunning on its own — or swap in Pagoeta natural park (waterfalls, forest, farm animals).

DAY 4 · SAT 20 JUN Drive west into Cantabria

🚗 Areitio → Cantabria base · **~210 km (2h30)** — the big transfer day

⏰ **Checkout before 10:00** at Areitio — pack Friday night, roll by ~09:45.

PICK ONE MAJOR STOP

- **A · Animals:** drive through → Cabárceno Wildlife Park (open-range elephants, bears, big cats + cable car; 3–4 hrs — Noah highlight).
- **B · Storybook + caves:** Santillana del Mar (one of Spain's prettiest villages) + Museo de Altamira cave-art replica.
- **C · Culture en route:** a proper Bilbao Guggenheim visit (35 min from Areitio; *Puppy*, *Maman*) then a lighter arrival.

EVENING

- Settle into your Cantabria base near Santander; relaxed dinner, early-ish night.

🏖️ **Great weather backup:** a Cantabrian beach — Somo/Loredo or Suances.

DAY 5 · SUN 21 JUN Fly home

🚗 Cantabria base → SDR · **15–45 min** (depends on the stay)

MORNING

- ⏰ **09:20 flight** → car return ~07:45 → leave by ~07:00–07:15.
- Free family priority security (AENA) — Noah free; Fast Lane info ↗.
- **11:10** land Charleroi → drive home.

BOOKINGS & STATUS

ITEM	STATUS	NOTE
Ryanair CRL↔Santander	Booked	FR6057 / FR6058
Hire car (Santander airport)	Booked	check a child seat for Noah is included
Areitio Etxea (base 1)	Book next	**non-refundable** — lock it in
Gaztelugatxe timed entry (Fri)	Book now	free but mandatory · tickets.bizkaia.eus ↗
Cantabria last night (base 2)	Deciding	Cabárceno + value, or closest to the 09:20 flight
Cabárceno / Altamira (Sat)	After Sat pick	Cabárceno ↗ · Altamira ↗

GOOD TO KNOW

🎒 Packing

- Layers + light rain jacket — Atlantic *sirimiri* drizzle even in June.
- Swimwear & towels (beaches + the pool).
- Comfy shoes — Gaztelugatxe steps & Santillana cobbles.
- Sun cream, a small daypack.

🚗 Driving

- A-8/AP-8 has tolls — a contactless card works at booths.
- Drive on the right; roads excellent.
- Lanes up to Areitio are narrow but easy.
- Everything from base is a 30–50 min drive — plan a driver for pintxos nights.

🔗 Book & navigate

🗺️ **Interactive map**
🏡 **Areitio Etxea** base 1
🎟️ **Gaztelugatxe tickets** free, book ahead
🦁 **Cabárceno park**
🖼️ **Altamira museum**
✈️ **Ryanair (manage)**

🍽 WHERE TO EAT — great wine + family-friendly · ★ ratings live from Google Maps, tap to open

🏡 Near the base · Durango

Kobika ★4.6 (884) · €20–70 · Basque, good wine list

Txanto Jatetxea ★4.5 (705) · €10–20 · central, great value

Mesoi Barria ★4.5 (1,369) · €10–20 · old-town favourite

🍢 San Sebastián

Ikaitz ★4.7 (1,673) · €30–80 · classic Basque, strong wine list

Astelena ★4.6 (1,596) · €50–90 · standout pintxos — great grazing for Noah

Zelai Txiki ★4.6 (1,272) · €€ · hilltop, relaxed & family-friendly

Arzak ★4.6 (2,065) · €100+ · 3-Michelin, world-class cellar — book ahead

🐟 Getaria · seafood + txakoli

Elkano Txiki ★4.7 (542) · €20–30 · casual & family-friendly, top value

Elkano ★4.7 (1,742) · €100+ · legendary grilled turbot + txakoli — book

El Astillero ★4.5 (1,813) · €40–90 · harbourside grill, great fish & wine

🏰 Cantabria · Santillana

La Nueva Santuca ★4.8 (663) · €20–40 · top-rated Cantabrian cooking

Gran Duque ★4.7 (2,144) · €20–30 · classic Cantabrian, good wine

Palacio Mijares ★4.6 (991) · €40–50 · manor-house dining + wine list

Pizzería Bitinia ★4.6 (3,611) · €10–20 · easy kid dinner near Santillana

All ≥4.5★ with 500+ reviews (Google Maps, live). Wine note: the asadores & fine-dining spots carry serious Basque txakoli / Rioja lists; pizza & pintxos picks are the relaxed kid options. Book Elkano & Arzak well ahead.